PHOTOGRAPHS BY COLWIN WAY

Smokers bow Windsor chair – part 1

Colwin Way shares his passion for constructing chairs

COLWIN WAY

Colwin started turning aged 13 and has since gone on to teach the craft and wishes to continue to give people confidence to try the wonderful hobby for themselves. Colwin was born and grew up in Lyme Regis, a small seaside town in the southwest of England, and is still living in the area with his wife Vicki and two sons, Finley and Charlie.

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In the grand scheme of things, I've been making chairs for a relatively short amount of time but find them extremely pleasing projects. I now teach Windsor chair-making for Axminster Tools and Machinery, along with fellow tutors Jason Breach and Ben Beddows. As tutors, we favour this course above all of the others. The reason for this is that the course takes six students with no woodworking experience through a whole variety of processes, tools, machinery and emotions. Yes, emotions: a lot of work goes into your first chair and when it all comes together, it is not unusual to see the odd tear or three. A normal Windsor chair for us would be a double bow involving steam bending, but for this project I'm going to make a smokers bow as this requires a lot more turnery.

I remember when I made my first chair with Stuart King and how incredibly excited I was when we were taken through the history of the Windsor with a slideshow before making our first cuts. Stuart then led us through a week of fun, swapping ideas and designs, all coming away with a great looking chair!

For this reason, I'm going to say to you that if you're looking at this project and thinking it's out of your ability, don't be afraid to give it a go. Follow the steps here and take your time, enjoy using the tools and realise what you are achieving. I always say to the students

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